trying to advance programs similar to those of Castro. Such programs, if undertaken … [could expose] United States property owners to treatment similar to that being received in Cuba and, in general, prejudicing the program of economic development espoused by the United States for Latin America which relies so heavily on private capital investment."[22] According to the Secretary of the Treasury, "'large amounts of capital now planned for investment in Latin America' were being held back, because investors were 'waiting to see whether the United States can cope' " with Cuba.[23] U.S. goals in Cuba, as elsewhere in Latin America, Rubottom reiterated, included "receptivity to U.S. and free world capital and increasing trade" and "access by the United States to essential Cuban resources."[24]

Thus the Secretary of State emphasized that "all actions and policies of the United States Government should be designed to encourage within Cuba and elsewhere in Latin America opposition to the extremist, anti-American course of the Castro regime."[25] A secret December 1959 CIA memorandum reiterated that Cuba's Revolution, "if permitted to stand, will encourage similar actions against U.S. holdings in other Latin American countries," and recommended that "'thorough consideration be given to the elimination of Fidel Castro" in order to "accelerate the fall of the present Government." In a handwritten note, the CIA director approved the recommendation.[26]

The 1975 U.S. Senate Committee investigation documented at least eight CIA-sponsored assassination attempts against Fidel Castro between 1960 and 1965, while the Cubans have documented numerous other attempts.[27] CIA officers poisoned a box of Castro's favorite brand of cigars with botulinum toxin, which would cause fatal illness within hours of ingestion. The cigars were delivered to a contact in February 1961, but apparently never made it into Castro's hands. Other murder weapons that the CIA prepared or obtained and delivered or arranged to have delivered to proposed assassins included lethal pills which a Cuban official was to place in Castro's food, a hypodermic needle filled with deadly insecticide and disguised as a pen, and high-powered rifles. CIA